

Michael's Linear Playbook

Michael’s Linear Workflow Guide

The operational playbook for managing Ella’s work across 4 ventures, 4 cycles, and the AI pipeline. Direct. Practical. No fluff.

The Full Architecture

You’re running 4 ventures through a single Linear workspace. The system is designed so Ella sees only her lane while you maintain the bird’s-eye view.

The 4 Ventures

Venture	Focus	Ella’s Role
Foundation	Infrastructure, tools, SEO setup, content systems	None — your domain
Production	Content creation pipeline (Ella’s primary workspace)	Voice memos, reviews, local expertise
Growth	Traffic, distribution, backlinks, social	Occasional review (does the content match strategy?)
Empire	New ventures, products, scaling	None (future)

The 4 Cycles

Each cycle is a 2-week sprint. All 4 ventures run in parallel, but Ella’s work lives almost exclusively in the **Production** cycle:

Cycle	What Happens	Ella Involved?
Foundation Cycle	AI tooling, site architecture, keyword research, Linear automations	No
Production Cycle	Interview tasks, AI drafts, Ella reviews, content publishing Distribution planning,	YES — her main lane

Growth Cycle	social content, link building	Occasionally (content review)
Empire Cycle	Product ideas, partnership research, future planning	No

Linear Initiatives (Projects)

Projects in Linear group related tasks. The key projects relevant to Ella's workflow:

Project	Purpose	Task Prefix
Active Oahu Content	All Oahu content pieces	GRO-xxx
Interview Pipeline	Interview → Draft → Review → Publish tasks	GRO-142 through GRO-147 (wave 1)
SEO Foundation	Keyword research, site structure	Ella not involved

The Dashboard View You Need

Set up your Linear sidebar with these pinned views: 1. **"Assigned to Ella"** — filter: assignee=Ella, not status=Done. This is your daily check. 2. **"Production Cycle — Active"** — filter: cycle=Production, not status=Done. Shows the full pipeline. 3. **"Blocked or Stale"** — filter: status=Blocked OR (status=In Progress AND updated > 3 days ago). Your intervention queue.

How to Assign Work to Ella

The assignment is the most important move you make. A well-assigned batch = smooth week. A sloppy assignment = confusion, rework, and Ella fatigue.

Batch Size: 5 Tasks. Never 6. Never 4. Five.

The number isn't arbitrary. Five tasks:

- Fits in ~1 hour of Ella's focused time
- Prevents the psychological paralysis of a long "Assigned to Me" list
- Lets the AI process in parallel (voice memo on task 1 gets transcribed while she's on task 2)
- Creates a natural cadence: assign → complete → celebrate → assign next

Exception: If Ella explicitly requests a smaller batch (fatigue, busy week), drop to 3. Never go above 5 unless she asks for more.

Clear Scope Is Everything

Every batch must have a **theme** and a **boundary**. Ella thrives when she knows exactly what "done" looks like.

☐ **Good Batch Assignments:**

“Batch 3: North Shore Voice Memos. 5 interview tasks — all recording, no reviews. ~10 min each. You covered the Windward side last week so these build on that momentum. Order doesn’t matter.”

“Batch 4: Draft Review. 5 AI-written articles ready for your eyes. Focus on: parking accuracy, hours of operation, and local vibe check. No voice memos this batch.”

“Batch 5: Mixed. 3 voice memos (GRO-150, 151, 152) + 2 reviews (GRO-148, 149). Do the voice memos first so the AI has time to process while you review.”

☐ **Bad Batch Assignments:**

“Here’s some stuff — do whatever order you want.”

Too vague. No theme, no boundary, no expectations set.

“15 new tasks for you! Take your time.”

Violates the 5-task rule. Even if you say “take your time,” seeing 15 tasks creates pressure.

“These are all urgent.”

Everything can’t be urgent. If everything is priority 1, nothing is. Sequence them.

Sprint Planning: The Cycle Board Method

Every 2 weeks, plan the Production Cycle:

1. **Review last cycle:** What shipped? What stalled? What patterns emerged in Ella’s feedback?
2. **Select 10-15 tasks** for the cycle (2-3 batches of 5). These go into the Production Cycle.
3. **Sequence the batches** using the confidence gradient (see below).
4. **Check capacity.** Is Ella traveling? Busy week? Adjust batch timing.
5. **Set the first batch live.** Assign 5 tasks to Ella. Leave the remaining 10 in Todo (not assigned).

The Confidence Gradient for Sequencing:

Batch 1: Topics she knows COLD (home beach, favorite spots)

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Batch 2: Adjacent topics (nearby areas, related activities)

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Batch 3: Synthesis/comparison topics (draws on Batch 1 + 2 knowledge)

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Batch 4: Reviews of AI drafts (she's now deeply familiar with the content)

Don’t front-load comparison or synthesis tasks. Build her confidence with easy wins first.

Task Assignment Checklist (Before Hitting Assign): - [] Batch size = exactly 5 - [] Each task has a clear, single deliverable - [] Task descriptions are ≤ 5 sentences (any longer $\rightarrow$ split or clarify) - [] Review tasks have a specific checklist (3-5 bullet points of what to look for) - [] Voice memo tasks have the questions attached or linked - [] Batch has a theme (communicated in the first task description or a batch note)

The Weekly Sync: 10 Minutes That Prevent Everything

This is your most important recurring meeting. It's short, it's casual, and if you skip it, problems compound silently.

The 3-Part Agenda (10 minutes total)

Part 1: Celebrate Wins (3 minutes)

Tell her specifically what she caught that was valuable. Be concrete:

"That catch on the Kailua parking situation — you saved us from publishing bad info during peak visitor season. That's exactly why you're in the loop."

"Your story about the turtle encounter in the Mokulua piece — that detail isn't on any other website. The AI can't generate that. That's your fingerprint on the content."

Why this matters: Ella has what we call an **open G Center** — she doesn't have a fixed sense of identity or self-worth. She needs external reflection to know what she's good at. Telling her what she did well isn't just nice — it's fueling her ability to keep doing good work. Without this, she'll drift toward uncertainty and second-guessing.

Part 2: Preview the Next Batch (4 minutes)

"Next up: 5 voice memos covering the North Shore spots — Waimea Bay, Shark's Cove, Pipeline, Sunset Beach, and the food trucks in Haleiwa. You've surfed up there, so these should be in your wheelhouse. I'm aiming to get those to you by Wednesday. No reviews this batch — just recording."

Give her: - The topic area - The task type (voice memos vs reviews) - Approximate timing - Any context about why this batch matters

This removes the surprise factor. Ella operates best when she can mentally prepare. Surprise assignments feel like demands; previewed assignments feel like teamwork.

Part 3: Listen for Fatigue (3 minutes)

Ask open-ended questions and LISTEN. Don't problem-solve immediately:

"How's the pace feeling this week?"

"Any tasks that felt particularly draining?"

"Is the 5-task batch still feeling right or should we adjust?"

Watch for these verbal signals: - “It’s fine” (translation: it might not be fine, but I don’t want to be difficult) - “I’ve been pretty busy with [other thing]” (translation: Active Oahu might be slipping) - “I’ll try to get to it” (translation: I’m behind and feeling guilty) - Long pauses before answering (translation: I’m processing whether I can be honest)

When you hear these: reduce batch size or switch to review-only tasks for the next round. Proactively offer: “Want me to cut the next batch to 3 so you have more breathing room?”

Ella’s Design-Aware Workflow

Ella operates differently from someone with a defined willpower or intuition center. Understanding her design is the difference between flowing work and constant friction.

Open Ego (Open Heart Center): No Fixed Willpower

What this means: Ella doesn’t have a consistent, reliable source of willpower. She can’t “power through” on discipline alone. Her energy comes in waves — some days she’s on, some days she’s off. This isn’t laziness; it’s her design.

How to work with it: - **Don’t overload.** 5 tasks per batch is the ceiling because willpower is a finite daily resource for her. More than 5 and she’ll start marking things “Done” without proper review just to clear the queue. - **Don’t make promises on her behalf.** She’ll say yes to things in the moment because she doesn’t have a fixed sense of what’s “too much.” You’re the gatekeeper. - **Batch variety helps.** Mixing voice memos and reviews keeps the energy fresh. 5 straight hours of either one is draining. - **Never ask “when can you get to this?”** It triggers people-pleasing answers. Instead: “This batch is ready — no rush, the AI will process whenever you get to it.”

Open Spleen (Open Splenic Center): No Fixed Intuition

What this means: Ella doesn’t have reliable spontaneous knowing. She can’t glance at a draft and instantly know if something is wrong — she needs to go through a checklist. Her intuition is inconsistent and environmentally influenced.

How to work with it: - **Give her checklists, not open-ended “does this feel right?”** questions. A checklist of 3-5 specific things to verify anchors her review process. - **Don’t ask “what’s your gut say?”** — her gut doesn’t have a consistent voice. Ask “does the parking section match what you know?” instead. - **She may hold onto drafts longer than necessary** because she doesn’t trust her own assessment. A gentle “I think you caught everything — want me to move this to Done?” can help. - **Environment matters.** She’ll make better calls after a good night’s sleep, in a calm setting, not rushed. The 24-hour rule exists because of this.

Open G Center: Needs Reflection

What this means: Ella doesn't have a fixed sense of identity or direction. She doesn't automatically know "I'm good at X" or "my role is Y." She needs external mirrors to reflect back who she is and what she contributes.

How to work with it: - **Tell her what she did well — specifically.** Every sync. "You caught the street direction error in the Lanikai piece" is 10x more valuable than "great work this week." - **Connect her contributions to outcomes.** "Because you flagged the sunscreen law, that article now ranks for 'reef safe sunscreen Hawaii' — that's actual traffic." - **Don't ask "what do you want to work on next?"** — she may genuinely not know. Offer options: "Next batch could be more North Shore voice memos or draft reviews — which sounds better?" - **Praise is fuel, not flattery.** It's literally how she knows what direction she's heading. Without it, she drifts.

The Combined Effect: A Workflow That Works

Her Design	Don't Do This	Do This Instead
Open Ego	Assign more than 5 tasks, push for speed, ask her to "power through"	Batch of 5, flexible timing, respect energy waves
Open Spleen	Ask for gut checks, rush decisions, expect instant knowing	Provide checklists, encourage the 24-hour rule, structure reviews
Open G	Give generic praise, ask "what do you want to do?", leave her without feedback	Specific praise every sync, offer options (not open questions), reflect her value

The Interview Pipeline: Task Flow Architecture

Understanding the exact movement of tasks through stages lets you diagnose bottlenecks instantly.

Full Flow Diagram

STAGE 0: PLANNING (You)

You create task in Linear → set assignee to "AI System" → task in Backlog

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STAGE 1: QUESTION GENERATION (AI)

AI reads topic → generates 7-8 interview questions → posts in task description

→ reassigns to Ella → status: Todo → appears in her "Assigned to Me"

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STAGE 2: VOICE MEMO (Ella)

Ella reads questions → records 5-10 min voice memo → comments with audio

→ status: In Review → AI picks up

↓

STAGE 3: DRAFTING (AI)

AI transcribes audio → cross-references with research → writes full

draft
 → posts draft in comments → status: In Progress → reassigns to Ella
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 STAGE 4: REVIEW (Ella)
 Ella reads draft → checks against checklist → comments with corrections
 → IF GOOD: status: Done → moves to publishing queue
 → IF CHANGES NEEDED: status: In Progress → AI picks up for revision
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 STAGE 5: REVISION LOOP (AI ↔ Ella)
 AI applies corrections → reposts → Ella reviews again → loop until Done
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 STAGE 6: PUBLISH (AI)
 AI formats final → SEO optimization → internal linking → marks complete

Pipeline States and Your Intervention Points

State	Owner	Normal Duration	Intervention Trigger	What To Do
Backlog	You	Indefinite	—	Assign when ready
Todo	Ella	1-3 days	> 5 days untouched	Check in: “Everything okay with this batch?”
In Progress (voice memo)	Ella	1-2 hours	> 3 days	She may be stuck on the questions — offer to simplify
In Review (AI drafting)	AI	2-6 hours	> 24 hours	System may not have triggered — ping AI or reassign
In Progress (review)	Ella	1-2 days	> 4 days	She may not trust her review — offer checklist
Blocked	Either	Variable	> 2 days	Direct intervention required — DM her

Common Pipeline Failures and Fixes

Symptom	Likely Cause	Fix
Task stuck in Todo for 5+ days	Ella overwhelmed or forgot about batch	Weekly check-in catch. Reduce next batch.

AI didn't pick up after Ella's comment	Comment too vague for AI trigger, or system delay	Check comment clarity. If good, reassign task to trigger AI.
Draft returned for revision 3+ times	Scope unclear or AI missing context	Review the original task description. Did it provide enough direction? Add context as a comment.
Ella marking everything Done quickly	Fatigue or disengagement	Reduce batch. Switch to voice memos only (less cognitive load than review). Check in.
Ella not commenting at all, just status changes	She doesn't understand comments drive the AI	Remind her: "The AI reads your comments to know what to do — even a one-sentence note helps."

How to Review Ella's Work

You're not reviewing her comments for grammar. You're checking the pipeline health and output quality. Review at the batch level, not the individual task level.

What to Review

Every batch (weekly): - [] Did she complete all 5 tasks within a reasonable window (3-5 days)? - [] Are her comments specific enough for the AI to act on? (Scan 2-3 comments per batch) - [] Did she catch things the AI missed? (If yes, celebrate in sync) - [] Are there any tasks where the review cycle went 3+ rounds? (Indicates a scope or clarity problem) - [] Is the output quality — the final AI-generated content — improving?

Spot-check tasks (monthly): - [] Pick one reviewed article. Read it as a user. Does it feel authoritative? - [] Compare the AI draft (before Ella review) vs. final. What did she actually catch? - [] Are there any factual errors that slipped through? (If yes, update the review checklist)

What NOT to Micromanage

- **Her word choice in comments.** “The parking situation is bad” is fine; it doesn’t need to be “parking availability is severely constrained during peak hours.” The AI handles polishing.
- **The order she does tasks within a batch.** As long as all 5 get done, sequencing is her call.
- **Her response time down to the hour.** As long as a batch turns around in 3-5 days, she’s on track.
- **Whether she uses voice memos or text.** Some days she might prefer typing. It doesn’t matter — the AI handles both.
- **How “professional” her comments sound.** Casual, conversational comments actually produce better AI output than stiff, formal ones.

The Quality Signal to Watch

The single most important metric: **Is Ella catching things the AI can’t?** If the answer is yes on 2+ tasks per batch, she’s delivering exactly the value she’s there for. If 0 per batch, something is off — either the tasks are too simple, the AI is over-performing (unlikely), or she’s disengaged.

Signs She’s Overwhelmed (And Exact Interventions)

Catch these early. Late intervention = burnout = content pipeline stops.

Signal	What It Looks Like	Intervention
Comment Shrink	“Looks good” on a draft with obvious issues. Comments drop from 3-4 sentences to 1-2 words.	Reduce batch to 3. Switch to voice memos only (less cognitive load). Say: “Noticing the reviews might be draining — want me to skip reviews this batch?”
Response Time Drop	Normal batch turnover: 3 days. Suddenly: 7+ days with no communication.	DM her directly. “Hey, no pressure — just checking if the current batch is feeling heavy. Happy to adjust.”
Clarification	She normally asks 1-2 clarifying questions per batch. Suddenly: zero	She’s either confused or checked out. Call it out gently: “I noticed no

Silence	questions, zero comments beyond bare minimum.	questions on this batch — everything clear or should I add more detail?"
In Progress Pile-Up	3+ tasks stuck in In Progress with no movement for 4+ days.	She's stuck and doesn't know how to unstick. Offer: "Want me to walk through one of these with you on a quick call?"
Repeated "I'll get to it"	Same batch, third time she's said she'll do it soon.	She's avoiding. Reduce scope drastically. "Let's make this batch just 2 tasks — pick whichever ones feel easiest. No rush."
Approving Without Reading	Multiple reviews marked Done within minutes of each other, with identical brief comments.	Burnout or overwhelm. Pause assignments entirely. "Taking a batch break this week — you've earned it. We'll pick up fresh next week."
Emotional Tone Shift	Comments go from warm/engaged to flat/curt.	She's depleted. Don't dig in — pull back. "The content can wait. Want to skip the sync this week too and just take the space?"

The Golden Rule of Intervention

Always frame reductions as your decision, not her failure. Never say "you seem overwhelmed." Say "I want to lighten the load this week" or "let's run a smaller batch while I catch up on the AI side." Protect her from feeling like she's letting anyone down.

Communication Cadence

When to talk, when to shut up, and what channel to use.

The Rhythm

Frequency	Channel	Purpose
Weekly	Voice or video call (10 min)	The sync: celebrate, preview, listen
As-needed (low urgency)	Linear task comments	Clarifications, status updates, praise on specific catches "Quick check —

As-needed (medium urgency)	DM (Telegram/Slack)	GRO-144 ready for review, whenever you get to it"
As-needed (high urgency)	DM with clear subject	"Need your call on Mokulua draft by Thursday — lmk if that timeline works"
Never	Between 8pm-8am her time	Unless she messages you first. Respect her off-hours.
Never	Email	She doesn't check it. Linear and DMs only.

When to Ping vs. Let Her Work

Ping when: - A task has been in In Progress for 5+ days with no update - You notice a quality signal (comment shrink, approval speed-up) and want to check in - A task in the pipeline is blocking 3+ downstream tasks - She hasn't acknowledged a batch assignment after 2 days - You're previewing the next batch (part of weekly sync)

Don't ping when: - A task has been In Progress for 2-3 days (normal cadence) - You're curious about progress (wait for the weekly sync) - You have a new idea for content (queue it; don't interrupt her current batch) - You want to say "great job" on something (save for the sync — mid-week praise can feel like pressure)

Praise Protocol

Public praise (Linear comments): > "Ella caught a critical detail here — the parking situation changed in 2023 and this draft had the old info. Great catch. Using this version."

Why: The AI logs it, she sees it in context, and it reinforces the human-in-the-loop value. Also gives the AI a signal that the corrected version is the final one.

Private praise (weekly sync): > "That Mokulua piece — your story about the turtle encounter. I checked and no other site has content like that. That's a ranking signal, and it came from you."

Why: Connects her contribution to business outcomes. Feeds the G Center.

What not to do: - Generic praise ("great job this week") — doesn't tell her what she did well - Praise that contradicts your own review standards ("looks perfect" when there were 3 corrections needed) - Praise as a prelude to criticism ("great work, BUT we need to talk about your speed")

The Cycle Board: Sprint Planning in Practice

Foundation → Production → Growth → Empire

The four ventures map to four cycle boards. Here's how to use them for sprint planning:

Week 1 (Sprint Start)

- └ Foundation: AI tooling, SEO audits, keyword research – (You + AI)
- └ Production: Assign Batch 1 (5 tasks to Ella) – (Ella + AI)
- └ Growth: Distribution planning – (You, no Ella)
- └ Empire: Research, ideation – (You, no Ella)

Week 1.5 (Mid-Sprint Check)

- └ Foundation: Audit progress
- └ Production: Check – did Ella complete Batch 1? Any stuck tasks?
- └ Growth: Content ready for distribution pipeline?
- └ Empire: Any findings worth escalating?

Week 2 (Sprint Close)

- └ Foundation: Deploy tooling improvements
- └ Production: Assign Batch 2 (5 tasks). Review Batch 1 output quality.
- └ Growth: Schedule social posts, outreach
- └ Empire: File findings for next sprint planning

Production Cycle — Detailed View

The Production Cycle is where Ella lives. Here's the board layout:

Column	Contains	Owner
Backlog	Tasks planned but not yet in this cycle	You
Todo	Tasks assigned to this cycle, not yet started	Ella
In Progress	Ella working or AI drafting	Ella + AI
In Review	Awaiting Ella's eyes or AI processing	Ella + AI
Done	Published or final-approved	AI
Blocked	Needs intervention	You

Monthly Planning Cadence

1. **End of month:** Review all 4 venture boards. What shipped? What's stuck?
 2. **First of month:** Set monthly content goals (e.g., "publish 8 articles this month"). This determines Ella's batch volume: 8 articles = ~16 tasks for Ella (interview + review per article) = ~3-4 batches.
 3. **Every 2 weeks:** Sprint planning. Move tasks from Backlog → Todo. Sequence batches.
 4. **Weekly:** Sync with Ella. Adjust based on her energy and capacity.
 5. **Daily:** 2-minute scan of "Assigned to Ella" and "Blocked or Stale" views.
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Summary Checklist

Weekly (Non-Negotiable)

- ☐ 10-minute sync with Ella (celebrate → preview → listen)
- ☐ Review “Assigned to Ella” for stalls (> 4 days in any status)
- ☐ Scan 2-3 comments for specificity
- ☐ Check: did any batch take > 5 days? (Investigate if yes)

Per Batch

- ☐ Batch size = exactly 5
- ☐ Each task has a single clear deliverable
- ☐ Review tasks include 3-5 item checklist
- ☐ Tasks sequenced by confidence gradient
- ☐ Batch has a communicated theme

Monthly

- ☐ Spot-check 1 reviewed article for quality
- ☐ Review output: is Ella catching AI-missable things?
- ☐ Adjust batch composition if needed (more/less reviews, more/less voice memos)
- ☐ Check alignment with monthly content goals

Red Flags (Immediate Attention)

- ☐ Comments shrinking below 1 sentence
 - ☐ Batch turning around in < 1 day (rubber-stamping) or > 7 days (disengagement)
 - ☐ 3+ Blocked tasks accumulating
 - ☐ Ella asking to reduce batch size unsolicited
 - ☐ Emotional tone shifting from warm to flat
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Quick Reference: When to Do What

Situation	Action
Ella finishes a batch early	Praise, then wait for next cycle to assign more. Don't pile on.
Ella's 3 days silent on a batch	“Hey, no rush — just checking if everything's clear on this batch?”
AI didn't trigger after Ella's comment	Reassign the task to trigger the AI workflow. Check comment clarity.
Ella flags feeling tired in sync	Immediately: reduce next batch to 3. Ask if reviews or voice memos are easier right now.
A draft goes through 3+ revision rounds	The original scope or task description was likely unclear. Audit and fix the

Ella catches a major error	template. Celebrate in task comments AND in weekly sync. Connect to business outcome.
A task needs to go live urgently	DM with clear deadline. “Need Mokulua review by Thursday — works for you?” Add as comment on task too.
You have a new content idea	Add to Backlog. Don’t interrupt current batch.
Ella asks for more work	“Love the energy! Next batch is ready — here it is.” (Still max 5.)
2-week sprint ends with unfinished Production tasks	Carry forward to next sprint. Investigate: was it an Ella capacity issue or AI pipeline issue?

This system works when you work the system. The most important lever you control is **batch size and clarity**. Get those right, and everything downstream flows. Get them wrong, and every other problem in this guide activates.

The second most important lever: **praising specifically**. It’s not optional. It’s how Ella’s design stays calibrated. Skip it at your own risk — and hers.

— The System